us to leave the airport. I called the police and informed them I had to leave for the hotel as soon as possible. A large number of security personnel accompanied me to the car while the crowd showered me with rose petals. The affection was overwhelming. Kolkata has always been a city that loves its cricket and the people there have always embraced me with warmth. I was delighted that the 199th Test match was being played at Eden Gardens, one of the best cricket grounds in the world when it comes to atmosphere.

During my first two days in Kolkata, Pintu (Raghunath Basak) gave me a massage for almost two hours each day to help me relax and my friend Samar Paul brought me food from home and we all had dinner in my room with Virat, Rohit, Ajinkya and Pragyan Ojha. I have known Samarda from 1991 and was first introduced to him by Dilip Vengsarkar. Every visit to Kolkata has been made special by the food that Samarda has kindly brought from home. Pintu too has been a constant in Kolkata from 1994, and it has been a routine that he would give me a massage and we would then end up having dinner in my room. Also, Joydeep Mukherjee would always take me to the Kali temple whenever I went to Kolkata, visits I have always looked forward to.

When I arrived at the ground on the morning of 4 November, I was very surprised by what was there to greet me. A wax statue of me was standing right outside the dressing room and the walls were covered with pictures of me from different stages of my career.

I tried to follow my normal pre-match routines as far as that was possible. I batted for a while in the nets, but I was fairly cautious while playing football with the rest of the boys, because the last thing I wanted to do was get injured. Afterwards we went back to the hotel and I went to the gym and later relaxed in my room watching movies and listening to music. It was all very normal. I ate dinner with my team-mates and was in a very good frame of mind.

Since the retirement announcement every news channel had been talking about my career and I tried to cocoon myself from it all as much as possible. I did see some of the coverage, however, and couldn’t help thinking about how many years had gone by since my debut. It was pleasing to be reminded of everything I had been able to achieve in my career, but I still had a job to do and I didn’t want to let myself get distracted. I did not want to retire mentally before I finally called it a day at the end of the second Test in Mumbai.